

The Definitive Guide to Getting Reviews



Insider tips and
techniques for building your
reputation online



Introduction

The strength of your reviews is one of the first things homeowners look at when determining whether to hire you for a project.

Reviews serve as online referrals to give you credibility and show potential clients what to expect if they hire you. Strong references from past clients can make the difference between an interested customer or lost business.

“Reviews are one of the most important tools for growing my business,” Eva Healy of Avenue Design says. “I always make sure I ask my clients for a review once the project is over and they’re happy with my work because they make such a big impact on getting new business.”

In this guide, we asked successful pros to share their proven tips and tricks for increasing the number and quality of reviews so you can attract more clients and close more deals.



Personalise your requests

Isn't it nice when you receive a personalised thank you note from a homeowner for completing their project? Your clients will feel the same way when they receive a personalised request for reviews. Generic messages may be easier to send, but they are less likely to convince clients to send a review.

"Our customers don't have time to read every email they receive, so we come up with personalised notes to catch their eye. There's nothing fancy about it and it costs us nothing but time," Cathy Cherry of Purple Cherry Architects says.

Creating an email template can make the process more efficient. "We keep the bulk of the message the same and then just personalise a few lines here and there to make it special," Jennifer Howard of JWH Design and Cabinetry says.

Always include the following in your emails:

- A personalised greeting with the client's name
- A thank you for their business
- An explanation about how reviews can help attract new clients
- A link to your Houzz profile where they can leave a review

Use one of these prompts to personalise your message:

- Ask clients how they're enjoying a specific feature you worked on
- If you got to know them on a personal level, ask them how their family is enjoying their new home
- During the holiday season, find out how they're decorating their space



Make reviews part of the process

It's common to think about mentioning reviews after the project is completed, but bringing them up from the start and throughout the project can keep reviews top of mind. Planting seeds from the beginning will make it easier to gather reviews at the end of the project.

"We try to mention reviews throughout the entire process from the first call to the design consultation, even during and after the project," Morgan Tedford of System Pavers says. "The customer isn't going to remember to write a review unless they see or hear the request at least three times. If they're thinking about reviews throughout the whole process, they'll be more likely to write us one after the job because they're more familiar with them."



Request multiple reviews at once

One way to make gathering reviews easier and more time efficient is to send out requests in batches. “We wait until several projects are finished and then send out a review request to all of our clients at once,” Jenny Sneller of Sneller Custom Homes says. “Sometimes we have to ask several times because they’re busy, so I find it easier to follow up with five requests instead of one here and there.”

Staying organised and keeping track of your past clients will make sure you don’t miss any opportunities. “I have an Excel doc that I use to keep track of projects I finish,” Howard of JWH Design and Cabinetry says. “Every couple of months, I’ll send out a bunch of review requests. If they respond, I’ll just check them off in my Excel doc. If they don’t, I’ll try again.”

Request with Houzz

Houzz makes it easy for clients to submit reviews. With the “Get Reviews” tool on your profile, just add the client’s email address and write a personalised note and Houzz will send the client directions to fill out the review. Once it’s approved, it will show up your profile.



Tap your professional network

To increase the number and scope of your reviews, you can reach out to your professional network as well. On Houzz, members of the professional community can fill out reviews as “Colleagues.” These reviews from your industry peers will provide a different angle of your business, which will impress not only potential clients, but also other professionals who may be looking to include you on a job.

Sharon Flatley of Sharon Flatley Design advises, “I try to get reviews from our contractors and subcontractors because that helps build credibility. As soon as the project wraps up, we tell them we can share photos with them so they can use it on their profile, but we ask them to review us first. It’s a win-win.”

Have you worked with another professional on Houzz? Let them know you’re writing a review for them and ask for them to do the same for you. They will receive an email when you complete the review, so they will be reminded to return the favour.



Thank your clients for thanking you

Responding to reviews shows that you truly value customer service because potential clients will see that you invest your time into communicating with all your clients. Houzz allows you to respond to your reviews with a thank you message and a 'Like'.

"It's important to acknowledge people who took the time to write a review," Tamara Akers of LTB Designs says. "That's just part of being courteous. When I read the review, it helps me maintain motivation and continue work. I like to acknowledge that and just say thanks." It also shows potential clients that you're responsive and appreciative.



Respond to negative reviews

Negative reviews are just as important to acknowledge and can actually be a positive marketing opportunity. Offering your side of the story or perhaps how you might improve the situation will allow potential clients to see how you handle situations that aren't ideal.

Michaelson Homes, LLC received a one star review with a client claiming the quality of work and materials were below expectations. Rather than staying silent, Michaelson Homes, LLC replied to the review with an apology and an explanation of their side of the story. "In order to save cost, the client used many of his own subcontractors, therefore limiting our control over the quality of work," a portion of their response states. "We at Michaelson Homes should have heeded the red flags that presented early on and have learned not to get involved in these types of projects in the future."

Serious clients will take the time to read both sides of the story, and showing that you're adept at handling any situation will resonate with savvy homeowners.



Persistence pays off

We know it can be tough to get reviews, but they're worth the effort it takes. Reviews are your best tool for closing new business by showing that you met or exceeded the expectations of past clients. The more reviews you have, the more likely potential clients are to see your business as credible and trustworthy, giving them confidence to contact you when they're ready to start their project.

"Reviews can be a challenge to get, but you just have to do it. Your customers look at those reviews and that's how they make the decision to hire you," Mark Montgomery of Montgomery Contracting says. "I'll ask all of my customers to write a review and sometimes they forget to do it, so I just keep reminding them. It takes a little time, but it's important."

Ask your account manager

If you're a Pro+ customer you'll have a dedicated Houzz account manager who can assist with reviews and more. They are always available to help you decide on the best process for getting reviews regularly and can even send requests on your behalf!

For more information, visit houzz.co.uk/proplus